

Who you study — and how the choice governs what you can claim

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Sampling is the selection of the units — people, organisations, documents — from which data is collected. Probability sampling gives every member of the population a known chance of selection and supports statistical generalisation. Non-probability sampling selects on other grounds (purpose, access, judgement) and supports analytical rather than statistical generalisation. The strategy must match the design: representativeness for quantitative work, information-richness for qualitative (Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill, 2019).

PROBABILITY SAMPLING

Random, systematic, stratified, cluster. Every unit has a known, non-zero chance of selection. Enables statistical inference to the wider population and estimation of sampling error. Requires a defined sampling frame.

NON-PROBABILITY SAMPLING

Purposive, convenience, snowball, quota. Units chosen for relevance, access or judgement. Cannot support statistical generalisation, but well-suited to depth studies where information-rich cases matter more than representativeness.

Match your generalisation claim to your sample. A convenience sample of 12 interviewees cannot support 'this is true of all SMEs'. State the target population, the frame (if any), the technique, the achieved size, and — honestly — the limits on what the sample lets you claim.

Type	Techniques	Generalisation	Fits
Probability	Random, stratified, cluster	Statistical	Quantitative
Non-probability	Purposive, snowball, quota	Analytical	Qualitative

STATE THE SIZE & LOGIC

Report target population, technique, achieved n, and why that size is defensible (power calculation for quant; saturation for qual).

SATURATION FOR QUAL

Qualitative sampling often runs until new interviews stop yielding new themes. Say when and how you judged saturation.

OWN THE LIMITS

Every sample has limits. Naming them in the methodology (and revisiting in limitations) shows rigour, not weakness.

Common pitfalls. (1) Generalising statistically from a non-probability sample. (2) No stated sampling frame for a 'random' sample. (3) An unexplained or arbitrary sample size. (4) Snowball sampling with no acknowledgement of its bias.

REFERENCES

Saunders, M., Lewis, P. and Thornhill, A. (2019) *Research Methods for Business Students*. 8th edn. Harlow: Pearson. · Etikan, I., Musa, S.A. and Alkassim, R.S. (2016) 'Comparison of convenience sampling and purposive sampling', *American Journal of Theoretical and Applied Statistics*, 5(1), pp. 1-4.